CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Antisemitism and the Return of Universalism in Contemporary France

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It has now become apparent that France is at the epicenter of what many scholars, including, most prominently, Robert Wistrich, have labeled the "new antisemitism" or the "new Judeophobia."[1] Home to the largest communities of both Muslims and Jews in Europe, France has witnessed a dramatic increase in attacks on Jews since the outbreak of the Second Intifada in 2000.[2] The brutal murder of three Jewish schoolchildren and their teacher in Toulouse in 2012 by a young man of Algerian descent, who claimed to be avenging his "brothers" in Palestine, focused the world's attention on the danger of the radical Islamist strain of Jew-hatred brewing on the margins of France's major cities. Far less attention has been paid, however, to a French intellectual strain located on the far left of the political spectrum, and more likely to be found in the chic cafés of the Boulevard Saint-Germain than in the housing projects of the disadvantaged suburbs. These far-left intellectuals do not shoot children or plant bombs, but they do shape debates, and many of them have had a major impact on intellectual life both in France and abroad, especially in American universities.

I want to take a closer look at a specific, and troubling, feature of the discourse of these far-left intellectuals: the way they deploy the concept of "universalism" to discredit those who denounce the new antisemitism, accusing Jews and their advocates of acting out of "communitarian" impulses when they defend against violence. To accuse someone of *communautarisme*, that is, of elevating ethnic or religious identity above national allegiance, is a serious business in France. The French republic prides itself on the suppression of ethnic or religious difference in the public sphere.[3] Communitarianism conjures the nightmare of an American-style multi-culturalism in which various ethnic or religious groups supposedly compete for power and authority, or for sympathy for their past sufferings, which amounts to the same thing in the eyes of those who fear such an ethnic and religious balkanization. To accuse someone of communitarianism, of violating the princi-

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Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,